

The PDRN Product Cheat-Sheet

How to tell a real PDRN product from a glow-washed bottle – in 30 seconds

The 30-second rule

Flip the bottle. Find the ingredient list. Look for **one of these two words**:

SODIUM DNA or **PDRN**

If it’s there, the product actually contains PDRN. If it’s not, “PDRN” on the front is decoration.

That’s the whole test. Marketing text, “salmon DNA extract” on the front panel, and influencer claims do not count. Only the INCI list counts.

Why this matters

PDRN is not a cheap ingredient, so many products include a token amount and lean on the label. Cosmetic chemists point out that ingredient lists don’t even tell you **where the DNA fragments came from** or **how much is in there**. So:

1. **Check the INCI list** for *sodium DNA* / *PDRN*.
2. **Check the position** – ingredients are listed in descending order. If sodium DNA sits after the preservative, it’s essentially a sprinkle.
3. **Check the delivery claim** – topical PDRN is most promising when paired with a delivery method (micronized delivery, a mask format, or use after professional microneedling/laser).

The PDRN product map

Format	Typical concentration story	Best for	Watch out for
Ampoule / serum	Highest, most concentrated	Daily Phase 3 use	Price inflation; verify INCI
Overnight mask	Medium, sits on skin for hours	Best accessible “delivery”	Fragrance on reactive skin
Cream / moisturizer	Lower, but barrier-friendly	Barrier-reactive skin, entry point	Weak PDRN dose
Essence	Low, watery layer	Layering in the Sandwich	Mostly water – don’t overpay
Clinic / ampoule after needling	Highest efficacy window	Real visible change	Cost, downtime, pro required

Rule of thumb: the *format’s delivery* matters as much as the concentration. An overnight mask often outperforms a watery essence that just evaporates.

Red flags (any one of these = walk away)

- “PDRN” on the front, **no sodium DNA** in the list
- Sodium DNA listed **dead last** (token amount)
- Promises “salmon sperm facial results at home in 3 days”
- **No ingredient list** published anywhere on the site
- Heavy **fragrance** / **essential oils** marketed to “sensitive skin”
- Bundled with a **microneedling roller** and told to “roll daily”
- Claims it “replaces Botox / filler / laser”
- No batch/lot info, no manufacturer address, no expiry

Green flags

- “... **Sodium DNA** or **PDRN** in the INCI, listed before the preservative
- “... States the **source** (salmon-derived vs. a plant/ginseng-derived)
- “... Honest about the **delivery caveat** (“best used after needling / in a mask”)
- “... Fragrance-free or low-fragrance formula
- “... Full INCI published, batch code, expiry
- “... Refund policy that doesn’t require an essay to claim

Vegan vs.Â salmon-derived

Salmon-derived PDRN is the original and the most studied. **Botanical PDRN** (e.g.Â ginseng-derived) has early evidence for supporting regeneration and barrier function, and is the option if you avoid animal-derived ingredients. Neither is â€œwrong.â€ Know which one youâ€™re buying â€” the label often wonâ€™t say.

How much to pay

Tier	Price	What youâ€™re buying
Drugstore / K-beauty basic	\$15â€“\$28	Entry-level PDRN, decent formula
Mid K-beauty	\$28â€“\$45	Higher dose, better delivery, better base
Premium ampoule	\$45â€“\$70+	Concentrated + brand tax
Clinic treatment	\$150+	The real delivery window

You do not need the premium tier to start. You need a barrier thatâ€™s ready, a product that actually lists sodium DNA, and consistency for 8 weeks. The \$26 option used correctly beats the \$70 option used randomly.

The 5-question buying checklist

Before you buy any PDRN product, answer:

1. Does the INCI list contain **sodium DNA / PDRN**? (yes â†’ continue)
2. Is it listed **before the preservative** (phenoxyethanol / parabens)? (yes â†’ continue)
3. Is it **fragrance-free** or low-fragrance? (yes â†’ continue)
4. Does it fit a **format youâ€™ll actually use** (serum youâ€™ll layer / mask youâ€™ll do weekly)? (yes â†’ continue)
5. Is your **barrier score 8+**? (yes â†’ buy. No â†’ go fix the barrier first.)

If you fail #5, buying more PDRN is throwing money at a wall with holes in it.

What to do with your current bottle

If you already own a PDRN product:

- Check the INCI. Real PDRN? Good â€” it goes in the Sandwich, Phase 3, 2 nights to start.
- No sodium DNA? Itâ€™s a hydrating essence. Use it as the wet layer in the Sandwich. No harm, no glow.
- Fragranced and your skin is reactive? Park it until your audit hits 8, then patch test.

Never throw away a working barrier routine for a new active. The bottle will wait. Your barrier wonâ€™t.

The PDRN Protocol, ç Â· Product Cheat-Sheet Â· Prices and formats are illustrative, verify the INCI on any product you buy. Educational use only.